



Bowling linchpin: Over the last two Border-Gavaskar series in Australia, only Australian skipper Pat Cummins (35 in eight matches) has taken more wickets than Bumrah (32 in seven).

GETTY IMAGES

BGT is a decision fraught with risk.

The form of its spin-bowling all-rounders also contributes to India's selection headache. While R. Ashwin and Ravindra Jadeja suffered one of their worst home series performances against New Zealand, Washington Sundar enjoyed a successful reintegration into the Test

fold. With Nitish Kumar Reddy in contention for the fast-bowling all-rounder spot, only one of Ashwin, Jadeja, and Washington will likely appear in Perth for the first Test. Form, experience, and match-ups will all come into play for coach Gautam Gambhir in a selection call, which could backfire quite easily.

Going into the Australian summer, the under-fire Indians, though, were gifted a brief ray of hope from an unlikely source — Pakistan. Their sub-continent rivals outmuscled the Aussies in the recent ODI series, bringing to light an underlying weakness against

high-intensity pace bowling.

Australia's only Test defeat in the last year came against West Indies at the Gabba, where a charged-up Shamar Joseph ripped through the home side with a seven-wicket haul in the fourth innings.

However, Australia bounced back from that loss by sweeping New Zealand away from home in a two-match series. Its bowling unit, led by Cummins, still retains the same personnel from the last BGT, armed with greater experience and driven by a hunger to reinstate the Aussie honour tarnished over the last two Indian visits.